Does the Belt and Road Initiative Promote the Building of a Community of Shared Future for Mankind along the Route?

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Abstract

Building a "Community of Shared Future for Mankind" (CSFM) is an unprecedented initiative for China to shoulder active responsibility and improve global governance as a major emerging power, in which process the "Belt and Road Initiative" (BRI) is the first practiced and the most anticipated exploration. The article is dedicated to investigating whether the policy shocks of the BRI have led to a higher level of the CSFM for the countries along the route using the "five connection" data and the difference-in-difference approach, through tackling the endogeneity problem by propensity score matching. The empirical results indicate that the BRI has significantly contributed to enhancing the note countries' level of the CSFM. In the coming stage, we should continue to promote the construction of the "five connection" of the BRI, especially the construction of the people-to-people connection, in order to promote the implementation of the CSFM.

Keywords: "Belt and Road Initiative", "Community of Shared Future for Mankind", "five connection", propensity score matching, difference-in-difference

JEL code: F15, F55, F60

I. Introduction

Throughout the evolution of human society, the historical process of globalization was once characterized by the capitalist economy accelerating the intensification of the inherent contradictions in global production relations and exporting of power logic squeezing the living space of developing countries. Since the new era, China's peaceful rise has emphasized building a win-win relationship of coexistence and coexistence with goodwill and tolerance, breaking the power politics and unequal development patterns, and presenting the world with a completely different picture of the future, rich in "Chinese wisdom".

The concept of community is the core of this vision. Marx emphasized that community is an inherent prerequisite for the survival and development of individuals as the sum of social relations, and that the ideal society of the future requires the construction of a "true community" that is not isolated and fully developed. Based on this assertion, General Secretary Xi Jinping put forward the idea of building the CSFM in his speech to commemorate the 70th anniversary of the founding of the United Nations. The CSFM is centered on the new order of governance of "discussing, building and sharing", fully respecting the will of all countries and attaching importance to the common interests and value consensus of all mankind, which has been generally welcomed by all countries in the world, especially the majority of developing countries.

Since the new coronary pneumonia epidemic ravaged the world in 2020, the global political and economic landscape has undergone significant changes, with some developed countries

diverting the crisis to the outside and the development interests of the majority of developing countries being seriously threatened, and the CSFM has shown unprecedented global strategic significance. Especially in the "post-epidemic era" when the epidemic has not yet ended, the restart of global economic politics and the restoration of global development norms as soon as possible must undergo a fundamental innovation of institutional mechanisms. The CSFM, as an important paradigm innovation in governance, will certainly play a pointing and leading role in this process.

The BRI is a form of globalization that is highly compatible with the CSFM. Since its launch in the fall of 2013, the BRI has been the largest cooperation platform globally, linking Europe and Asia and demonstrating China's active participation as a responsible power in the reshaping of the global governance paradigm. China's idea of CSFM has also taken root in countries around the world along with this extended road of cooperation, friendship and solidarity, and has gained the attention and recognition of more and more countries.

As a multilateral cooperation strategy with significant influence in the region, does the BRI significantly impact the countries along the route to improve the level of community building and adapt to the CSFM? This paper uses an empirical approach to provide an answer to this question. The paper constructs a method to measure the level of building the CSFM based on the "five connection" index, then uses the propensity score matching (PSM) method to match the scores of the participating countries with those of the non-participating countries, and uses the difference-in-difference (DID) method to obtain the evaluation of the impact effect. Finally, mechanism analysis and robustness test are also conducted in this paper.

II. Literature Review

1. Definitions and Origins

The "Community of Shared Future for Mankind" (*Renlei Mingyun Gongtongti*, CSFM)[1] is one of the "overarching goals of China's foreign policy in the years ahead" (Wang 2017), which is very significant for understanding Chinese diplomacy and international strategy in the new era (Zhao 2018, Ye 2019, Zeng 2020).

After the 15th APEC meeting in Sydney, the People's Daily published a commentary called "The connotation of "A Community of shared future'", which for the first time proposed the expression the CSFM with a similar meaning to the present one.[2] In September 2011, The "China's Peaceful Development" White Paper proposed that "It should find new perspectives from the angle of the community of common destiny to identify new dimensions in the common interests and values of mankind", further explaining the meaning of the CSFM.[3]

As Jinping Xi began China's supreme leader as general secretary of the Communist Party of China (CPC) and president of the People's Republic of China (PRC), the CSFM has become a recurring political slogan, reflecting his thoughts and visions of Chinese diplomacy and world domination (Xi 2014). After elaborating this term at the 18th National Congress of the CPC in November 2012,[4] President Xi followed up mentioned the CSFM in his visit to the Moscow

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[1] The term of the CSFM is variously translated as "Human Community with Shared Future", "Community of Shared Density", "Community of Common Density", and so on. The expressions used in the text are the current official usage.

[2] "A Community of 'shared future'", published 7 September 2007 on the People's Daily.

[3] "China's Peaceful Development", published 6 September 2011 by State Council Information Office on its website, http://www.scio.gov.cn/ztk/dtzt/58/3/Document/999959/999959_1.htm, accessed 12 April 2022.

[4] "Report at the 18th Party Congress", http://news.xinhuanet.com/18cpcnc/2012-11/17/c_1 13711665.htm, accessed 12 April 2022.

International Institute, which was his first visit to a foreign country as president.[5] Subsequently, he kept expounded on this concept on many important occasions, such as UNESCO,[6] 70th Session of the UN General,[7] and the UN Office.[8] Finally, the phrase was written into the CPC's constitution at the 19th Party Congress in October 2017, and into the PRC's constitution at the meeting of the National People's Congress in March 2018,[9] becoming a national strategy and high-level will.

Although the terminology of CSFM has evolved over a long period of time, its primary meaning has not changed, while its connotation has been gradually enriched. Literally, the CSFM means all mankind share a community of fate on only earth and only world, in which the members should be closely interconnected and achieve a win-win by working and developing together (Wang 2017, Yang 2018, Zeng 2020).[10] Many scholars, such as Zhang (2018) and Zeng (2020), argues that the CSFM is vague and symbolized so that is probably to be empty propaganda without concrete policy ideas. The BRI is such an attempt to practice the CSFM and make it the deliverable promise (Globe 2017, Marcelli 2019).

Back in the Qin and Han dynasties, the opening of the Silk Road (the Land Silk Road began in the Qin Dynasty, and the Maritime Silk Road began in the Western Han Dynasty) connected China to many countries, allowing the world and China to understand each other (Frankopan 2016). In the 21st century, contemporary China, on the basis of the glory history of the Silk Road, proposed to build the BRI.

The BRI[11] is consist of two core concepts: the Silk Road Economic Belt (SREB) and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road (CMSR), the former is announced at Nazarbayev University on 7 September 2013 by President Xi and the latter is unveiled during his visit to Indonesian on 3 October 2013,[12] corresponding to the two parts of the ancient Silk Road. Since the BRI was proposed, China's neighboring countries have generally welcomed it and joined the cooperation framework enthusiastically. So far, China has signed more than 200 cooperation documents with 148 countries and 32 international organizations (see Table A1 in appendix for the list of countries) to build BRI together, thus creating a pioneering work and a popular public good in the field of international development(Liang and Zhang 2019).

As a concrete practice of the CSFM, the BRI is dedicated to promoting regional communication and development though win-win cooperation and joint prosperity (Huang 2016, Liang and Zhang 2019). In this process, the BRI places particular emphasis on flexibility to circumvent the rigidity and strictness of the traditional RTA framework (Mao, Liu et al. 2019), though "five connection"

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[5] "Conforming to the trend of the times and promoting peaceful development in the world", published 24 March 2013 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/20893328, accessed 12 April 2022.

[6] "Speech at UNESCO Headquarters", published 28 March 2014 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/24759342, accessed 12 April 2022.

[7] "Join hands to build a new partnership for win-win cooperation and build a community of human destiny with one heart ", published 29 September 2015 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/27644987, accessed 12 April 2022.

[8] "Building a Community of Shared Future for Mankind together", published 20 January 2017 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/29037132, accessed 12 April 2022.

[9] "Constitution of the Communist Party of China", http://www.china.org.cn/20171105001.pdf, accessed 12 April 2022; "Constitution of the People's Republic of China", http://english.www.gov.cn/archive/lawsregulations/201911/20/content_WS5ed8856ec6d0b3f0e9499913.html, accessed 12 April 2022.

[10] It is important to note that academics have mixed take on whether the CSFM indeed makes it the goal and can achieve it, as well as the BRI below, and this will be discussed later.

[11] It is also officially termed as the "One Belt One Road Initiative" (OBOR) in some other files.

[12] "Promoting people's friendship and building the 'Silk Road Economic Belt' together", published 7 September 2013 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/22843681, accessed 12 April 2022; "Five insistences to build China-ASEAN community of destiny", published 3 October 2013 on the People's Daily, http://jhsjk.people.cn/article/23101183, accessed 12 April 2022.

indicators, where infrastructure connectivity plays a central role, and policy dialogue, unimpeded trade, financial support and people-to-people exchange also count (Huang 2016). In fact, the "connection"(*Tong,* 通) in BRM somehow explains the "common"(*Tong,* 同) in CSFM, that is, it is the function of promoting the connectivity of BRI countries that achieves the goal of the community of CSFM.

2. Theories and Comments

The above definitions and statements on the CSFM and the BRI reflect China's vision and expectations for improving international governance and promoting common development, in times of greater economic interdependence and growing political divergences.[13] Although most scholars agree with this view, some scholars have different voices on this issue. A key question is: Is China really aiming and working for the ideal purpose of the CSFM and the BRI, or is it a slogan to achieve China's political machinations and ambitions? Does China have the capacity to achieve the CSFM and the BRI's purpose?

Support viewpoints are all alike; every opposing viewpoint opposes in its own way. Nathan and Zhang (2022) criticize that the CSFM and the BRI are political slogans and tools of China that are fundamentally aimed at pursuing the political objectives behind them. They argue that the actual actions of Chinese diplomacy are often the opposite of its political slogans, and that the BRI and the CSFM are likely to become tools for China to bully and profit from its position as a major power over smaller countries (Gill 2007, Nathan and Scobell 2012), some scholars even suggest that these two concepts are vague, empty, and conceptual slogans that have no possibility of being put into practice (Zeng 2020). Not only that, but the slogan also has logical problems, emphasizing the equality of nations on the one hand, while the superior and honored status of China on the other (Nathan and Zhang 2022). Many scholars have also pointed out that the CSFM and the BRI reflect that China has abandoned its original foreign policy of "hide and bide" and has begun to seek world dominance and become the next world hegemon (Zhao 2018). Other scholars have pointed out that even if the BRI does aim to promote the community's building and common development, it is unlikely to be realized due to China's lack of national power and serious geopolitical conflicts among countries along the route (Nye 2017, Wang 2018).

Numerous scholars have responded to the above critique. First, respond to the negative comments about purpose and motivation. There is no doubt that the CSFM and the BRI share two general reasons: the goal at home and the international consideration (Liang and Zhang 2019). Just as no country will act against its own interests (Bremmer 2012), China's proposal to build the CSFM and the BRI is certainly based on Chinese considerations and in its own interests, and there is no contradiction between the pursuit of common development and the development of China itself, which are two sides of the coin. Huang (2016) points that China attempts to change its development mode and develop high-tech, high-value-added industries, in order to improve Total Factor Productivity (TFP) and deal with the "middle-income trap" challenge. Consequently, the cooperation brought by the CSFM and the BRI is considered as a proper way to achieve industrial upgrading and reverse the decline in economic growth. However, beyond such a purpose, China also emphasizes the export of advantageous industries and actively contributes to regional development and common construction as a fellow developing country and expands areas of

[13] "Secure a Decisive Victory in Building a Moderately Prosperous Society in All Respects and Strive for the Great Success of Socialism with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era", published 18 October 2017 at the 19th CPC National Congress, http://www.xinhuanet.com/english/special/2017-11/03/c 136725942.htm, accessed 12 April 2022.

converging interests on the basis of mutual benefit (Yang 2018).

Second, the "political slogan" argument does not hold water. On the one hand, the logical contradiction of "equality and superior status" does not exist. The rationale for this view is that the CSFM and the BRI have their spiritual roots in traditional Chinese culture and that many of Confucius' ideas are contrary to equality, such as "the loyal to the ruler, the son to the father, the wife to the husband, the younger brother to the elder brother". In fact, this is a misunderstanding of traditional Chinese thought. Confucianism has a lot of discussions about "common" (Gong). Confucius, in his era, had proposed the idea of "Grand Union" (Fung 2010, Li 2017), whose expression is such as: "Men did not love their parents only, nor treat as children only their own sons". Mohist's "universal love and non offensive" is also part of traditional Chinese thought, and there are many more examples to demonstrate the importance of cooperation in Chinese culture, not to mention the fact that China, which was deeply influenced by communism, also absorbed many ideas from Marxism. On the other hand, China has sufficient capacity to invest in building the CSFM and the BRI, and has in fact put a lot of effort into it. For example, Export and Import Bank of China alone lent $80 billion in 2015, compared with more than $27 billion from Asian Development Bank;[14] by the end of 2019, the stock of China's direct investment in countries along the BRI was $179.47 billion, accounting for 8.2% of China's outward direct investment stock.[15]

Lastly, China has no intention of exporting its values and seeking political hegemony through the CSFM and the BRI. Many people in Western societies have believed in populism, isolationism, and unilateralism in recent years, therefore troubled in understanding China's development path. Unlike the old "legal community" "humanitarian community" and "community of interest", the core spirit of CSFM is the integrity and commonality of the interests of nations and even of human being (Zhang 2018). In response to the distinctions and differences between countries, the CSFM and the BRI can interface with the development strategies of countries, including Russia's "Eurasian Economic Union", the African Union's "Agenda 2063", and so on, based on mutual consultation and understanding to achieve common benefits (Liang and Zhang 2019). Moreover, China, which has suffered from imperialism, feudalism, and bureaucratic capitalism since the Opium War to the foundation of the PRC, and resented negative part of existing international order dominated by the United States, thus never aspiring to the diplomatic philosophy of hegemonism (Marcelli 2019). China's propose to build the CSFM and the BRI aims that "Great powers should shoulder greater responsibilities and make more contributions".[16]

The above scholars' views form a sufficient refutation of the opponents' views, however, they are mostly based on theoretical and logical arguments and fail to provide strong data evidence. This paper provides improvement on this point.

Hypothesis 1a: the BRI promotes the building of the CSFM significantly;

Hypothesis 1b: the BRI doesn't promote the building of the CSFM significantly.

III. Data, Variables, and Methodology

1. Data and Variables

The key to the data and empirical part of this paper is how to construct the "five connection"

[14] "Where will China's 'One Belt, One Road' initiative lead?", published by Knowledge@Wharton on 22 March 2017.

[15] "2019 China Outbound Direct Investment Statistical Bulletin", published on "China Belt and Road Network".

[16] "Speech of Foreign Ministry Spokesperson on Regular Press Conference", published 17 May 2017 on the website of Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, accessed 12 April 2022.

indicators. There have been many empirical studies on similar topics that include the construction method of the "five connection" indicators, for example, Mao, Liu et al. (2019) use joint statements, transport connection, burden of customs procedure, borrowers from commercial banks and Hofstede cultural distance to measure policy dialogue, infrastructure connectivity, unimpeded trade, financial support and people-to-people exchange, respectively, Lu, Gu et al. (2021) quantifies political communication more carefully, and so on.

However, these methods are not applicable in this paper, because most of the existing quantitative approaches to the indicators are based on a Chinese perspective and measure various types of relations between China and foreign countries, rather than state-to-state relations. That is, for the three countries codenamed A, B, and C, most of the existing studies focus on the bilateral relations between country A and B and C, but not on the relations between countries B and C. However, if the study measures the bilateral relationship between each two countries, data acquisition, processing and computation would become extremely difficult for a cooperation framework of the scale of BRI.

This paper chooses to construct the "five connection" indicators by evaluating the conditions and environment of communication and connectivity rather than directly measuring the level of connectivity itself. For each country, a better connectivity environment means greater opportunities for connectivity, and thus higher levels of it. Connectivity conditions and environments differ from connectivity levels in that a country's connectivity environment is essentially the same for all other countries, thus avoiding the need to collect hundreds of thousands of data and endless calculations.

On this basis, we selected 10 countries from the list of countries participating in the BRI and 10 countries from the list of countries not participating in the BRI by descending order of GDP, as the treatment and control groups for the difference-in-difference model in the later section (see Table 1 for the list of countries selected). In addition, a number of covariates were selected for the propensity score matching model in the latter part of the paper. The methods of data collection and generation are shown in Table 2.

Table 1. List of Country Selected

Region	Country	Amount
Treatment group	China, Italy, Korea, Russia, Indonesia, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, Poland, Thailand, Venezuela	10
Control group	United States, Japan, German, United Kingdom, India, France, Canada, Brazil, Australia, Spain	10

Note: Compiled by the author.

Table 2. Methods of data collection and generation

Variables	Data source	Definitions and generate methods
I_{pol}	World Justice Project	Rule of law index, which has 8 components[17]
I_{lpi}	World Bank	Logistics performance index, which has 6 components[18]
I_{tra}	World Bank	Calculated by total imports and exports divided by GDP

[17] They are: constraints on government powers, absence of corruption, open government, fundamental rights, order and security, regulatory enforcement, civil justice and criminal justice.
[18] They are: customs, infrastructure, ease of arranging shipments, quality of logistics services, tracking and tracing and Timeliness.

I_{fin}	World Bank	Foreign Investment Restrictions Index
I_{peo}	World Tourism Organization	Number of international tourism arrived
C_{pop}	United Nations	Population of the country
C_{dev}	United Nations	If the country is a developed country, yes = 1 and no = 0

Note: Compiled by the author.

Based on this, the paper assigns and aggregates the indicators of five different dimensions through the "Technique for Order Preference by Similarity to Ideal Solution" (TOPSIS) method to form the final "five connection" indicator. The TOPSIS method first normalizes the data, then calculates the distance of each solution from the optimal and inferior solutions respectively, and generates scores accordingly. The final results are normalized to the interval 0-1 (See Table A2 in the appendix for the weight of variables). The results of descriptive statistics for all the variables are shown in Table 3.

Table 3. Descriptive statistics

Variables	N	mean	sd	min	max
I_{pol}	240	0.636	0.140	0.270	0.840
I_{lpi}	240	3.481	0.459	2.070	4.230
I_{tra}	240	58.00	24.83	10.97	139.7
I_{fin}	240	0.150	0.116	0.0200	0.440
I_{peo}	240	5.024e+07	5.631e+07	177,000	2.179e+08
I_{tot}	240	0.323	0.172	0.0904	0.809
C_{pop}	240	221,430	386,036	21,751	1.439e+06
C_{dev}	240	0.500	0.501	0	1

Note: Compiled by the author.

2. Methodology

Academics have long contributed many methods to study the policy implications of the BRI. Some scholars adopt an ex ante perspective to assess the possible impacts of the BRI by constructing various hypotheses and models, such as Clausing (2001) and Zhai (2018); others adopt an ex post perspective to evaluate the causal effects of the BRI policies, such as Lu, Gu et al. (2021) and Du and Zhang (2018). Among the studies with ex post perspective, the difference-in-difference (DID) approach is particularly popular among researchers, which is also adopted in this paper.

The DID model is often used to assess the effects of policies, and is therefore sometimes referred to as the "program evaluation model", whose idea and rationale is simple: if the implementation of a policy creates two groups in a world, then the difference in effect between the policy implementation group (also called the experimental or treatment group) and the non-implementation group (also called the control or comparison group) can be considered as the effect of the policy. Critically speaking, consider a counterfactual framework (Rubin, 1974), using $D_i = \{0,\ 1\}$ to represent the policy involvement of individual *i*, so there is:

$$y_i = \begin{cases} y_{1i},\ if\ D_i = 1 \\ y_{0i},\ if\ D_i = 0 \end{cases} \tag{1}$$

Based on which, the DID can give an estimate of the policy effect (also known as the average treatment effect on the treated, ATT):

$$\text{ATT} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \text{E}(y_{1i} \mid D_i = 1) - \text{E}(y_{0i} \mid D_i = 1) \tag{2}$$

The process, which is to subtract the difference between before and after the control group from the

difference between the effects before and after the treatment group, explains the origin of the DID name.

However, what the researcher is really interested in is not really the ATT but the average causal effect (ATE), that is, how big the gap is between the current treatment group situation and the treatment group in parallel time that is not affected by the policy, which can be expressed as:

$$\text{ATE} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \text{E}(y_{1i} \mid D_i = 1) - \text{E}(y_{0i} \mid D_i = 0) \tag{3}$$

So, if we define the differentiation between ATT and ATE as average treatment effect on the untreated (ATU), there is:

$$\text{ATU} \stackrel{\text{def}}{=} \text{E}(y_{0i} \mid D_i = 1) - \text{E}(y_{0i} \mid D_i = 0) \tag{4}$$

and

$$\text{ATE} = \text{ATT} + \text{ATU} \tag{5}$$

Consequently, in order to make the ATT and ATE close enough, an important approach is to make ATU small enough, i.e., to make the policy non-implementation natural states of the two groups similar enough. Because whether or not countries along the BRI choose to join it is not a random event (each country has considerations and trade-offs due to its own interests), there is a self-selection problem for the two groups. The endogeneity problem, that country-pairs with some economic characteristics tend to form RTAs or other similar regional institutional arrangements (Baier and Bergstrand 2004; Krugman 1991), must be considered; otherwise the empirical results will be biased.

In order to deal with the self-selection problem, the paper use propensity score matching (PSM) method to select similar samples in two groups, making the ATU as small as possible. Referring to Vidal (2007) and Magee (2008) et al., we construct logistic regressions using covariates such as population size and whether it is a developed country to generate propensity scores for the treatment and control groups, and match them by multiple matching methods. The logistic model is:

$$I^*_{tot,it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 C_{pop,it} + \beta_2 C^2_{pop,it} + \beta_3 C_{dev,i} + \varepsilon_{it} \tag{6}$$

Where the probability model is:

$$\text{P}(I_{tot} = 1 \mid x) = \text{P}(I^*_{tot} > 0 \mid x) \tag{7}$$

Use the equation (6) and (7), the propensity score $p(x)$ can be calculated and interpreted as the likehood of joining the BRI. After the PSM, the DID was done on the remaining sample with:

$$I_{tot,it} = \gamma_0 + \gamma_1 Treat_i Post_t + \gamma_2 Treat_i + \gamma_3 Post_t + \delta X_{it} + \varepsilon_{it} \tag{8}$$

In which the γ_1 is the concerned coefficient of the DID. If it is positive and significant, then it means that the BRI does impact the CSFM positively.

VI. Empirical Results

1. Baseline Empirical Results

Table 4 (graph in Figure A1 in the appendix) shows the calculated results of PSM with matching results. Since most of the countries joining the BRI are developing countries, while most of the countries not joining the BRI are western developed countries, the “five connection” indicator differs significantly between the treatment and control groups, and there is a certain number of unmatched samples, but the matching samples are still sufficient for the next analysis.

Table 4a. PSM Results of ATT, ATU, and ATE

Sample	Treats	Controls	Difference	T-stat
Unmatched	3.223	3.738	-0.515**	-10.51
ATT	3.310	3.406	-0.096**	-8.57

ATU	3.727	3.553	-0.174***	-24.33
ATE			-0.144***	-18.15

*Note: Compiled by the author. Inference: *** p<0.01; ** p<0.05; * p<0.1*

Table 4b. PSM Results of Matching

Treatment	Off Support	On Support	Total
Untreated	30	90	120
Treated	62	58	120
Total	92	148	240

Note: Compiled by the author.

On this basis, the basic empirical results from equation (8) are shown in Table 5. $Treat_i Post_t$ is the core variable of DID and model (1) presents the relationship between it and the dependent variable. Although the coefficient is significant, the R^2 of the equation is very low. Model (2) is the result of adding the control variables and the regression result is still significant. Model (3) is the regression result with robust standard errors, and the above conclusion still holds. All regressions were performed based on fixed effects.

An important fact is that $Treat_i Post_t$'s coefficient is always positive after the introduction of the control variables, which implies that the effect of the BRI on the CSFM is positive, confirming the hypotheses of this paper.

Table 5. Baseline Empirical Results

Variables	(1) I_{tot}	(2) I_{tot}	(3) I_{tot}
$Treat_i Post_t$	-0.029***	0.016***	0.016***
	(-3.79)	(2.94)	(3.55)
$Treat_i$		-0.024***	-0.024***
		(-5.16)	(-6.32)
$Post_t$		-0.005	-0.005*
		(-1.55)	(-1.76)
C_{pop}		0.000***	0.000***
		(6.48)	(6.53)
C_{pop}^2		-0.000***	-0.000***
		(-5.65)	(-5.63)
C_{dev}		0.131***	0.131***
		(17.52)	(19.07)
$Constant$	0.364***	0.241***	0.241***
	(92.50)	(23.53)	(24.74)
FE	YES	YES	YES
Observations	148	148	148
R^2	0.090	0.885	0.885

*Note: Compiled by the author. Inference: *** p<0.01; ** p<0.05; * p<0.1*

2. Impact Mechanisms

Next, we will discuss how the BRI contributes to CSFM building. As mentioned in the previous article, an important index to evaluate the level of community building is the "five connection" index. Therefore, we regress each of the five indices as the dependent variable, and the results are

shown in Table 6.

Table 6. Impact Mechanisms

Variables	(1) I_{pol}	(2) I_{lpi}	(3) I_{tra}	(4) I_{fin}	(5) I_{peo}
$Treat_i Post_t$	0.043**	0.070***	4.117*	-9.026*	-1.983e+09
	(2.24)	(2.77)	(1.71)	(-1.89)	(-0.41)
$Treat_i$	-0.035**	-0.131***	8.314***	17.807***	-3.704e+09
	(-1.99)	(-6.07)	(3.53)	(3.81)	(-0.89)
$Post_t$	-0.004	-0.029*	1.788	3.842	2.648e+09
	(-0.58)	(-1.71)	(1.48)	(1.62)	(0.77)
C_{pop}	0.000*	0.000***	0.000***	0.000***	46,039.069
	(-1.69)	(6.10)	(3.36)	(2.95)	(1.39)
C_{pop}^2	-0.000	-0.000***	-0.000***	-0.000***	-0.014
	(1.53)	(-5.33)	(-3.27)	(-2.91)	(-0.66)
C_{dev}	0.190***	0.741***	25.737***	44.930***	3.466e+10***
	(14.08)	(18.78)	(8.15)	(7.17)	(7.88)
$Constant$	0.589***	1.424***	9.569**	7.097	1.154e+09
	(31.94)	(25.43)	(2.40)	(0.89)	(0.17)
FE	YES	YES	YES	YES	YES
Observations	148	148	148	148	148
R^2	0.841	0.896	0.620	0.567	0.461

*Note: Compiled by the author. Inference: *** p<0.01; ** p<0.05; * p<0.1*

The coefficients of it for the four indicators of politics, infrastructure, trade, and finance are all significant, with the first two of them having higher significance, which indicates that the BRI has better promoted the above levels of cooperation. However, the people-to-people connection is not significant, which indicates that the current impact of the BRI is still insufficient and needs to be emphasized in the future construction.

3. Robustness Test

In this paper, the robustness of the empirical process is tested by different kinds of PSM matching methods. Using nearest neighbor matching, caliper matching, and mahalanobis distance matching, we obtain results that are generally consistent (see Table 7). This indicates that the above conclusions are robust and plausible.

Table 7. Robustness Test

Method	Off support	On support	Total
Mahalanobis	0 unmatched	120 unmatched	0 off support
	0 matched	120 matched	240 on support
Caliper	64 unmatched	56 unmatched	141 off support
	77 matched	43 matched	99 on support
Radius	64 unmatched	56 unmatched	141 off support
	77 matched	43 matched	99 on support
Caliper and Radius	64 unmatched	56 unmatched	141 off support
	77 matched	43 matched	99 on support
Mahalanobis, Caliper	30 unmatched	90 unmatched	92 off support

and Radius	62 matched	58 matched	148 on support

Note: Compiled by the author.

V. Conclusion

At this point, we have come to the conclusion that the BRI has significantly contributed to the improvement of the level of community among countries in the region, in line with the trend of globalization, multilateralism, and the expectations of the CSFM. The BRI has contributed to the building of a community, with outstanding results in infrastructure connectivity and policy communication, as well as significant development in trade and finance, while people-to-people communication needs further attention and development.

The BRI is a vivid practice of the CSFM, and its contribution to promoting regional development, progress and integration is outstanding and unimpeachable. The so-called "insights" of "China conspiracy theory", "China hegemony theory" and "China threat theory" cannot drown out the solidarity, cooperation, consensus and benefits that the BRI brings to the countries along the route. Consequently, there is no reason why the BRI will not play a greater role and value in countries along the route.

The leading role of infrastructure connectivity should be further emphasized. One of the major advantages of the BRI is that it allows developing countries to build infrastructure based on the support of AIIB rapidly. Infrastructure connectivity will guarantee the further improvement of other indicators, bringing the countries along the Belt and Road closer together.

Political consensus is the foundation of the BRI, and political stability and consensus are the basis for economic stability and progress. Political mutual trust, win-win cooperation, non-interference in other countries' sovereignty and development wishes, and cooperation based on equality and progress will completely reverse the old unjust world governance order and form a new "Chinese wisdom" and "Chinese philosophy".

We should pay attention to the leading role of trade exchanges and financial cooperation in the construction of the community. The community of interests is the keynote of the BRI, and smooth economic cooperation is decisive for the construction of the community. At present, the countries along the BRI still have large differences in economic development levels, resource endowments, industrial structure and others, so the community building process from the economic perspective is still promising. Economic development, the interests of the people's livelihood, should be a proud card of the BRI, and become a model of sincere cooperation and pragmatic progress of regional organizations worldwide.

The people-to-people connection needs to meet head-on. The cultural factor is the most complex and problematic in the countries along the BRI. The cultural inclusion advocated by the BRI is not a "cultural fusion" or "cultural integration", but a blossoming of all cultures. In this sense, the relative lack of contribution of cultural factors is rooted in the absence of in-depth exchanges and smooth institutional mechanisms for cultural contacts. As a prominent feature of the new type of BRI, the exploration of the community in the field of culture needs to explore the numerous possibilities in the new era, playing a greater role in the construction of the elemental system of the CSFM.

Appendix

Table A1. List of BRI Note Country

Region	Country	Amount
Africa	Sudan, South Africa, Senegal, Sierra Leone, Côte d'Ivoire, Somalia, Cameroon, South Sudan, Seychelles, Guinea, Ghana, Zambia, Mozambique, Gabon, Namibia, Mauritania, Angola, Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Nigeria, Chad, Congo, Brazzaville, Zimbabwe, Algeria, Tanzania, Burundi, Cape, Verde, Uganda, Gambia, Togo, Rwanda, Morocco, Madagascar, Tunisia, Libya, Egypt, Equatorial Guinea, Liberia, Lesotho, Comoros, Benin, Mali, Niger, Congo (DRC), Botswana, Central Africa, Guinea-Bissau, Eritrea, Burkina Faso, Sao Tome and Principe	51
Asia	Korea, Mongolia, Singapore, East Timor, Malaysia, Myanmar, Cambodia, Vietnam, Laos, Brunei, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Bangladesh, Nepal, Maldives, UAE, Kuwait, Turkey, Qatar, Oman, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Iran, Iraq, Afghanistan, Azerbaijan, Georgia, Armenia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Thailand, Indonesia, Philippines, Yemen, Syria	38
Europe	Cyprus, Russia, Austria, Greece, Poland, Serbia, Czech Republic, Bulgaria, Slovakia, Albania, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, Estonia, Lithuania, Slovenia, Hungary, North Macedonia, Romania, Latvia, Ukraine, Belarus, Moldova, Malta, Portugal, Italy, Luxembourg	27
North America	Costa Rica, Panama, El Salvador, Dominica, Trinidad and, Tobago, Antigua and Barbuda, Dominica, Grenada, Barbados, Cuba, Jamaica, Nicaragua	12
South America	Chile, Guyana, Bolivia, Uruguay, Venezuela, Suriname, Ecuador, Peru, Argentina	9
Oceania	New Zealand, Papua New Guinea, Samoa, Niue, Fiji, Federated States of Micronesia, Cook Islands, Tonga, Vanuatu, Solomon Islands, Kiribati	11

Note: Taken from "China Belt and Road Network", https://eng.yidaiyilu.gov.cn/, accessed 12 April 2022.

Table A2. The Weight of Variables through TOPSIS model[19]

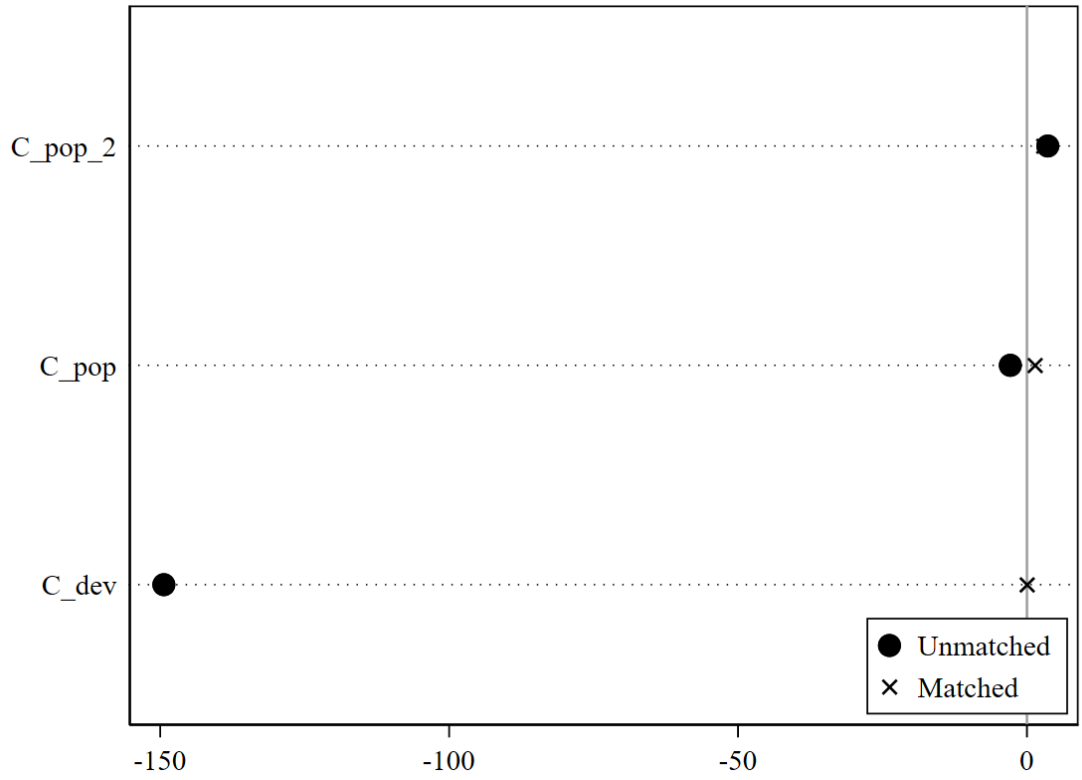
Variables	Informationentropy	Information utility	Weight
I_pol	0.984	0.016	0.093
I_inf	0.989	0.011	0.567
I_tra	0.976	0.024	0.145
I_peo	0.902	0.098	0.083

[19] Because the "five connection" index emphasizes infrastructure development in particular, we have increased the weight of it and reduce the weight of people-to-people connection.

Variables	Informationentropy	Information utility	Weight
I_fin	0.981	0.019	0.113

Note: Calculated by the author.

Figure A1. PSM Results Graph



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